

World War I and the Struggle for Irish Independence

World War I

World War I began in **1914** after the assassination of **Archduke Franz Ferdinand** in Sarajevo. This single event triggered a huge conflict between two sides: the **Central Powers**, led by Germany and Austria-Hungary, and the **Allies**, which included Britain, France, Russia, and their partners. Italy stayed neutral at first but joined the Allies in **1915**.

Germany planned a quick victory over France by marching through Belgium. This violated Belgian neutrality and brought Britain into the war. At first, many people across the British Empire were full of patriotic enthusiasm. However, the war turned into a **long and exhausting conflict**, far from the fast victory Germany expected.

Soldiers on the Western Front faced terrible conditions: mud, disease, constant danger, and new weapons like **machine guns, tanks, and poison gas**. Many soldiers suffered from **shell shock** — what we now call post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). Attacks on enemy lines often caused massive casualties. At the **Battle of the Somme**, around **60,000 British soldiers** were killed or wounded on the first day alone.

In **1917**, the **United States** entered the war, aiming to "make the world safe for democracy." Their involvement helped bring the war to an end. An armistice was signed on **11 November 1918**, and the **Treaty of Versailles** followed in **1919**. The main leaders at the peace negotiations were **David Lloyd George** (Britain), **Georges Clemenceau** (France), **Woodrow Wilson** (USA), and **Vittorio Emanuele Orlando** (Italy). Wilson proposed the **Fourteen Points** and the creation of the **League of Nations**, though the U.S. Senate refused to join it.

The cost of the war was enormous: millions of soldiers and civilians died, **four empires collapsed**, and major political changes followed — including the **Russian Revolution** and the rise of dictators like **Benito Mussolini** and **Adolf Hitler**.

The Struggle for Irish Independence

The **Act of Union (1801)** joined Great Britain and Ireland into a single state, ending Ireland's own Parliament. During the 19th century, many Irish people wanted **Home Rule** — the right to govern themselves. However, this was strongly opposed by northern **Unionists** and the British Conservative Party. Several Home Rule bills were proposed between **1885 and 1914**, but none passed. When World War I broke out, the issue was postponed, and many Irishmen went to fight for Britain.

In **1916**, the **Easter Rising** took place in Dublin. It was led by the **Irish Republican Brotherhood**, who tried to declare an independent republic. The rebellion did not have much popular support at first, but the British government responded with **executions and mass arrests**. This harsh response turned public opinion, and the rebels became **national heroes**.

In the **1918 elections**, **Sinn Féin** won almost all Irish seats and refused to go to the British Parliament in Westminster. Instead, they created their own independent parliament, the **Dáil**, in **1919**. This led to the **Irish War of Independence**, led by **Michael Collins**, which ended with the **Anglo-Irish Treaty of 1921**. The treaty

created the **Irish Free State** as a self-governing dominion, but **six northern counties** remained part of the United Kingdom.

The treaty caused deep divisions among the Irish, sparking a **Civil War (1922–1923)**, won by pro-treaty forces. **Éamon de Valera**, one of the leaders of the 1916 Easter Rising, later became a major political figure and **President of Ireland (1959–1973)**. Easter Monday remains a **symbolic date in Irish politics**. Later agreements, like the **1998 Good Friday Agreement**, helped bring lasting peace to **Northern Ireland**.